

people are never happy with what they have, Felix seemed perpetually happy.

Even to his family and friends, Felix always maintained his cheerful demeanor. When asked the common greeting, “How are you?” Felix always answered, “Wonderful.” Felix’s wife Lola developed a sense of assurance about the family’s finances. She had no idea what their financial situation was, but she was quite confident that it, too, was under control.

Only Felix knew the real truth. His gambling addiction had gotten out of control years before. The losses had always been covered up first by his student loans and then his expanding medical practice. As long as he continued to grow his practice and make a lucrative living, he had nothing to worry about.

Unfortunately, Felix didn’t count on his addiction becoming worse. He started gambling more often and placing larger bets to cover his increasing losses. He worked longer hours at his practice as his worry intensified. Even though Felix was scared to death, he hid his fears from everyone, including his wife.

Most gamblers, like Felix, are ignoring mathematical realities. You are eighty times more likely to die by flesh-eating bacteria than win the Powerball jackpot. On average, if you play \$50 every month, you’ll lose half of your investment the first month, leaving you with \$25. The following month you add \$50 to the \$25 you put back in, and you again lose half. The pot is now down to \$37.50.

Believe it or not, following this cycle for forty years, after pouring \$24,000 into the lottery, the typical player will have just \$50 left. While the average investor can grow that nest egg to \$387,000, the average lottery player will be left only with enough for a nice dinner. This reality is ignored though, because many gamblers truly believe that they will eventually

